

THE MERCHANT OF VENICE, ACT ONE—STUDY QUESTIONS

SCENE 1

1. What is Antonio's occupation?
2. What is Antonio's problem at the beginning of the play?
3. To what do Salerio and Solanio attribute Antonio's disposition?
4. What advice does Gratiano give Antonio regarding his disposition?
5. How does Bassanio characterize Gratiano?
6. What does Bassanio reveal to Antonio about his financial status?
7. What does Antonio reveal to Bassanio about his financial status? How does he offer to help Bassanio?

SCENE 2

1. What is Portia's problem at the beginning of Scene 2? How does Nerissa respond?
2. What is Portia's attitude/tone regarding the suitors that Nerissa describes?
3. What do we learn about Portia's father's will in this scene?
4. Of whom does Nerissa remind Portia at the end of this scene? How does Portia react?

SCENE 3

1. What deal does Bassanio present to Shylock?
2. What does Shylock reveal during his long *aside* (lines 38-49)?
3. How does Antonio contradict himself during the meeting with Shylock?
4. How does Shylock characterize Antonio? What does he reveal about his past dealings with Antonio during his *monologue* (lines 103-126)?
5. How does Antonio respond to Shylock's accusations? What does Antonio's response reveal about his character?
6. Describe the "merry bond" that Shylock proposes.
7. What is Antonio's attitude/tone as he accepts Shylock's offer?

THE MERCHANT OF VENICE, ACT TWO—STUDY QUESTIONS

SCENE 1

1. What does the Prince of Morocco ask of Portia at the beginning of the scene? How does she respond?
2. What additional information do we learn about the “lottery” devised by Portia’s father?

SCENE 2

1. What is Launcelot debating over at the beginning of the scene?
2. What reason does Launcelot offer his father for leaving Shylock’s service?
3. What favor does Gratiano ask of Bassanio at the end of the scene? How does Bassanio respond?

SCENE 3

1. Why is Jessica so disappointed by Launcelot’s news?
2. What favor does Jessica ask of Launcelot?
3. What does Jessica reveal during her short soliloquy at the end of the scene?

SCENE 4

1. What event are the men preparing for at the beginning of the scene?
2. Describe the plan that Jessica outlines in her letter to Lorenzo.

SCENE 5

1. Why does Shylock finally decide to accept Bassanio’s dinner invitation?

THE MERCHANT OF VENICE, ACT THREE—STUDY QUESTIONS

SCENE 1

1. What rumor from the previous act is confirmed by Salerio at the beginning of Act 3?
2. How does Salerio characterize Shylock's relationship with his daughter?
3. What important points does Shylock make during his speech to Salerio and Solanio? (lines 50-69)
4. What news does Tubal report to Shylock at the end of the scene?
5. How does Shylock react to Tubal's news?
6. What is the significance of the turquoise ring? How does Shylock react to Tubal's news about this particular item?

SCENE 2

1. What does Portia want Bassanio to do at the beginning of the scene? How does he respond?
2. What theme is illustrated during Bassanio's lengthy commentary on the chests? (lines 73-107)
3. Which chest does Bassanio choose? What is the result?
4. How does Portia characterize herself during her lengthy speech to Bassanio? (lines 149-174)
5. What does Portia give to Bassanio at the end of her speech?
6. What is the result of Gratiano accompanying Bassanio to Belmont?
7. What news is contained in the letter that Salerio delivers to Bassanio?

8. What advice does Portia give Bassanio at the end of the scene?

SCENE 3

1. How does Shylock respond to Antonio's pleas for mercy?
2. Why does Antonio think that Shylock hates him? Is his theory accurate?

SCENE 4

1. Why does Portia ask Lorenzo and Jessica to watch and manage her house?
2. What does Portia reveal to Nerissa at the end of the scene?

SCENE 5

1. What "warnings" does Launcelot give to Jessica and Lorenzo? How does Lorenzo respond?
2. What is the purpose of this closing scene?

THE MERCHANT OF VENICE, ACT FOUR—STUDY QUESTIONS

SCENE 1

1. What expectation does the Duke express regarding Shylock's decision to pursue his pound of flesh?
2. How does Shylock respond to the Duke's expectation? What reason does he offer for pursuing the pound of flesh?
3. How does Antonio respond to Shylock's demands? What is Antonio's general attitude throughout Act 4? (See lines 6-13, 70-83, 114-118, and 263-280)
4. How is Shylock able to lawfully demand the pound of flesh?
5. What does Shylock do to provoke Gratiano's anger? How does he respond to the outburst from Gratiano that follows?
6. Who is Bellario? How is he able to get Portia involved in the trial?
7. How does Portia (as Balthasar) respond to Antonio's admission of guilt?
8. How does Bassanio ask Portia (as Balthasar) to handle the case? How does she respond?
9. What loophole does Portia (as Balthasar) finally use to turn the case around?
10. What is the final outcome of the trial?
11. What does Portia (as Balthasar) want from Bassanio at the end of the scene? Why?

SCENE 2

1. What does Gratiano deliver to Portia (as Balthasar)?
2. What plan does Nerissa reveal at the end of the scene?

THE MERCHANT OF VENICE, ACT FIVE—STUDY QUESTIONS

SCENE 1

1. What is the significance of the opening conversation between Jessica and Lorenzo?
2. What request does Lorenzo make of Stephano? What theme is illustrated in this scene?
3. What do Portia and Nerissa do with the rings that they took from Bassanio and Gratiano in the previous act?
4. What good news does Portia deliver to Antonio?
5. What good news does Portia deliver to Jessica and Lorenzo?